

MANDAR DEODHAR

CINEMA

"TANAAV IS DIFFERENT FROM FAUDA"

Director **Sudhir Mishra's** *latest project is an Indian adaptation of the hit Israeli series,* Fauda. Tanaav, *the SonyLIV series, follows a special unit in Kashmir. Mishra has also finished post-production for* Afwaah, *a thriller starring Bhumi Pednekar and Nawazuddin Siddiqui, shot a short film with Taapsee Pannu and is writing a series based on his grandfather's memoirs*

Q Your past few projects have been adaptations of international shows and a book.

I'm a filmmaker, so when I started doing long-form, I tried first to get the hang of it. It helps if you're working with material that's partly constructed. Of course, you have to adapt and bring your own self into it. Adapting *Serious Men*, based on Manu Joseph's book, was more difficult. While adapting from a book, you go from the abstract to the concrete, whereas with a show, you already have scenes and situations constructed.



This is where the region you are adapting for and who the filmmaker is come into play. *Fauda* revolves around the Palestine-Israel conflict. *Tanaav* is set in Kashmir, so it's different. We've also made it religion-neutral, in that most characters are Muslim. I hope that it will start conversations.

Q. *Fauda* was criticised for being skewed towards Israel. Was that something you had to keep in mind?

Unlike *Fauda*, *Tanaav* is about one country and every character is Indian. This also makes it more complex. You might disagree with, sometimes understand and even lament the wrong choices that some characters make, but you know them because they are of the same nationality. While there is an attempt to understand the other side, it's very clear whose side the show is on.

Q. Tell us about the series you're writing inspired by your grandfather Dwarka Prasad Mishra, a former chief minister of Madhya Pradesh.

My maternal grandfather was among those in the late '60s who brought Mrs Gandhi to power. Then there was the inevitable disappointment with the rise of Sanjay Gandhi in '74, and he left [the Congress party]. The series that I am writing is loosely based on his memoirs and on recollections of people from that era, like a man called Ramesh Dixit who was in a student's union. There is also the JP movement happening in Bihar. I am still in the process of writing this, though.

Q. Would it be accurate to say this is the busiest phase of your 40-year-long career?

Yeah, suddenly people think I'm good at a lot of things. It also has a lot to do with the kind of person in charge who's greenlighting shows and films. Like Anubhav Sinha, who has a production house. We go back a long time and admire each other's work. There's Applause's Sameer Nair, who I think is one of the most well-read people I've ever met. There was a time when producers thought I was too educated and asked too many questions. This was a handicap. Even though I wrote *Jaane Bhi Do Yaaro*, it was a struggle for me to make my own film. Though it did well even then and went on to become a cult film, no one gave me work. ■

with Karishma Upadhyay

WATCHLIST

NEW SEASONS



WHITE LOTUS
Disney+ Hotstar

Creator Mike White continues his deep dive into white privilege, class hierarchy and complex relationships, this time at a luxurious hotel in Sicily. There's satire, scenic locations and, of course, a dead body or two.



HOSTEL DAZE
Amazon Prime Video

The Viral Fever's popular series is back with another season full of misadventures in an engineering hostel.



ENOLA HOLMES 2
Netflix

Millie Bobby Brown plays a teenage sleuth whose brother is a certain Sherlock Holmes (played by Henry Cavill). The siblings end up solving a case together.